

B-17 bomber crew
The crew of a B-17 bomber returns to its base in England after a bombing raid over Germany *(above)*. Each crew member was issued with an inflatable life vest *(right)* in the event of being downed at sea; pulling the cords released carbon dioxide into the jacket's inner tubing.

THE US BOMBER CREWS who flew B-17 Flying Fortresses and B-24 Liberators on daylight missions over Germany and Occupied Europe suffered some of the highest combat losses of any US forces in World War II. Flying daylight missions, initially without fighter escorts, they were vulnerable to anti-aircraft fire and to attack from German fighter aircraft. In order to hit their assigned targets deep inside hostile territory, the bomber formations had to "shoot their way in and shoot their way out again".

All US Army Air Force fliers had volunteered for service in the air. Mostly in their late teens or early 20s, they came from every part of the US and every occupational background, from stockbrokers to farmhands – although virtually all were white, as a consequence of the determination of senior air force commanders to keep blacks out of aerial combat. Bomber crews received extensive training at American bases before being sent abroad to fight. A B-17 crew had four officers – a pilot (the senior-ranking officer, often a captain), who was the flight commander, a co-pilot, a bombardier, and a navigator. It also had six NCOs, namely a radio operator, a flight engineer, two waist gunners, a tail gunner, and a ball-turret gunner. Each officer or enlisted man was taught the specialist skills corresponding to his role in the aircraft. The pilots, in particular, had to master flying in close formation, which led to quite a few fatal training accidents. A crew might have around 360 flying hours under its belt before completing training, but nothing could prepare them adequately for what they faced when they arrived in the European theatre.

STRATEGIC BOMBING

The USAAF mounted its strategic bombing campaign from bases in England, North Africa, and, later, Italy. Air force commanders believed that their fast, heavily armed bombers could carry out precision raids on targets such as factories or sources of fuel supplies. The bombers would attack in daylight, flying at high altitude in mass formation. In theory, a combination of speed, altitude, and overwhelming firepower would ensure their survival – and use of the new, sophisticated Norden bombsight would allow their bombardiers to deliver the payload on the target.

THEORY AND PRACTICE

But combat did not work out as planned. Accurate bombing proved an elusive ideal. The weather in Europe was completely different to the clear blue skies of the southern or western United States where the bomber crews had trained. Targets were liable to be obscured by cloud, and, in any case, under combat conditions few bombardiers were capable of operating their complex bombsights successfully. The Americans soon opted for a system in which only the lead bomber in the formation used the bombsight; the rest dropped their bombs when the leader did. Worse than the lack of accuracy was the problem of survival. Losses in the first phase of the bombing campaign in 1943 were staggering. When 376 B-17s raided factories at Schweinfurt and Regensburg on 17 August 1943, for instance, 60 bombers were shot down and another 11 so badly damaged they had to be written off.

For crews at a US air base in eastern England in 1943, the day of a combat mission started early. Woken at around 3am by an operations officer snapping on the lights in the crowded hut where they slept, they would stumble through the darkness to a briefing room, where the day's mission was outlined.



US ARMY AIR FORCE LIFE JACKET